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'THE TWILIGHT OF UTOPIA': BRITISH DYSTOPIAN FICTION AND THE COLD WAR

There is a long-standing academic engagement with American literature's response to the events and ideologies of the Cold War. From the 1980s onwards, critics have analysed the ways in which American poets, novelists, and dramatists addressed such topics as McCarthyism, the Korean War, the US–Vietnam War, Soviet containment, and arms escalation. So significant was the final of these that there emerged during the early 1980s a specific literary theory—so-called Nuclear Criticism—that focuses on the conscious and unconscious impact of nuclear technologies and of the widespread fear of nuclear disaster.¹ Moreover, critics have argued that the Cold War was the guiding influence on all major forms of cultural and philosophical expression in the period. Tobin Siebers, defining the Cold War as 'the story of our skepticism about endings, intentions, interpretations, and calculations concerning numbers, troop movements, weapons, negotiations, and claims to truth and falsehood', charts its influence both on the styles and concerns of postmodernism and on the fascination with paradox, ambiguity, and indeterminacy exhibited by literary theories from New Criticism to poststructuralism.² Yet despite similar historical phenomena occurring in Britain, an equivalent scholarship does not exist. Adam Piette's comment that criticism is 'sometimes bafflingly indifferent to the importance of the Cold War in shaping cultures' is evidenced by a general decoupling of British literary practice and Cold War history, although also by overt claims that such practice, as one critic argues, 'demonstrated relatively little direct engagement with the events and issues that arose over the time'.³

The oversight is all the more notable when considering Britain's role in international affairs. While American historians have traditionally viewed the Cold War as a US–Soviet matter, the involvement of British governments in European security, covert operations, arms talks, propaganda, and summitry is now acknowledged.⁴ According to the 'British hypothesis', it was Whitehall assessments of the Soviet threat, motivated by concerns over the defence of the

¹ Nuclear Criticism has retained its relevance in the post-Cold War era, when such fear derives, not from US–Soviet conflict, but from conflicts in other parts of the world: see Ken Ruthven, *Nuclear Criticism* (Victoria: Melbourne University Press, 1993), p. 10, and Patrick Mannix, *The Rhetoric of Antinuclear Fiction: Persuasive Strategies in Novels and Films* (London: Associated University Presses, 1992), pp. 172–73.

² Tobin Siebers, *Cold War Criticism and the Politics of Skepticism* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993), p. 29.

³ Adam Piette, *The Literary Cold War: 1945 to Vietnam* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 2009), p. 5; Steve Padley, *Key Concepts in Contemporary Literature* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2006), p. 20.

⁴ For the purposes of this essay, I shall take 1945 as the starting date of the Cold War, although the origins of the conflict are debated and other dates—1917, 1939, 1941, 1947—have been suggested by historians.

Empire, that first encouraged the US shift from isolationism to containment. These assessments came in such rhetorical moves as Churchill's 'Iron Curtain' speech, with its vision of 'Communist fifth columns' mounting a 'growing challenge and peril to Christian civilisation',⁵ and in the work of the Russia Committee and the Information Research Department, which disseminated anti-Soviet propaganda via television, radio, and film, and later attempted to 'roll back' Communism in eastern Europe. Although the latter failed, the Foreign Office's warnings prompted US engagement in West Germany, Turkey, Greece, and Iran, all threatened by Communist incursions during the 1940s, and also helped to inspire the Truman Doctrine, with its promise of assistance to countries threatened by left-wing movements. In part, the reliance on American strength indicated Britain's decline from 'great power' status. A series of economic crises meant dwindling defence budgets, outmoded military resources, and ongoing fears of Soviet encroachment on colonial territories from Egypt to Malaya. By 1947 the Foreign Office had begun viewing Britain and its European neighbours as 'pigmies between two giants'.⁶ In the new superpower struggle over Third World resources, the British Empire and sterling area were even challenged by the US, most obviously in 1956, when it obstructed the British occupation of Egypt after the nationalization of the Suez Canal.⁷ Yet Ernest Bevin's dream of the nation as a global third force was not wholly relinquished. Its commitment to European security during the so-called 'first Cold War', as seen in occupied Germany, the Brussels Pact, and the creation of NATO, was later augmented by Attlee's attempts to temper US hostilities towards China, by Churchill's calls for summit talks with the Kremlin, by Macmillan's historic visit to Khrushchev during the Second Berlin Crisis, and by Wilson's promotion of the Non-Proliferation Treaty of 1968, all of which facilitated the détente of the 1970s. As one historian argues, the 'idioms of the early Cold War—globalism, domino theory, nuclear deterrence, containment, *détente* and summitry—could claim to be British conceptions' prior to 'being appropriated by the Americans'.⁸ Just as Britain helped to shape the course of global events, so those events shaped aspects of British life, from the Welfare State and the peace movement, through nuclearization, decolonization, unionism, and recession, to Labour's retreat from socialism and the quandaries of post-imperial nationhood. By the 1980s Britain's role as the 'architect of the West's Cold War confrontation with Russia' was long forgotten,

⁵ Churchill's 'Iron Curtain' speech, in *Twenty Years of Crises: The Cold War Era*, ed. by Young Hum Kim (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1968), pp. 16–19 (p. 17).

⁶ Quoted in Sean Greenwood, *Britain and the Cold War, 1945–1991* (Basingstoke: Macmillan, 2000), p. 53.

⁷ See Nicolas J. White, *Decolonisation: The British Experience since 1945* (London and New York: Longman, 1999), pp. 26–28, 76–88.

⁸ Greenwood, pp. 139, 194.

but Thatcher's burgeoning defence budget, pathological anti-Sovietism, and zealous attacks on the domestic left revealed an unflagging participant.⁹

The dystopian genre offers a condensed guide to the multiple responses of British fiction to Cold War realities. From 1945 to 1989 dystopianism was an expressly Cold War literary mode and, far from having 'little direct engagement' with geopolitical currents, proved reluctant to engage with anything else. The mid-twentieth-century growth of this admonitory genre, which imaginatively intensifies contemporary trends in order to caution against them, stemmed from the flourishing in the period of idealistic blueprints for political change. The concern had already been present in earlier twentieth-century fiction: G. K. Chesterton's *The Napoleon of Notting Hill* (1904), E. M. Forster's story 'The Machine Stops' (1909), H. G. Wells's *The Sleeper Awakes* (1910), Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932), Katharine Burdekin's *Swastika Night* (1937), and C. S. Lewis's *That Hideous Strength* (1945) each 'satirizes both society as it exists [. . .] and the utopian aspiration to transform it'.¹⁰ After 1945, however, with the memory of the Holocaust, the reports of Stalinist atrocities, and the insidious spread of US hegemony, the fear of political idealism intensified. 'During the Cold War', Fredric Jameson argues, 'Utopia had come to designate a program which [. . .] betrayed a will to uniformity and the ideal purity of a perfect system that had to be imposed by force on its imperfect and reluctant subjects'.¹¹ This crisis of faith extended to critical studies of dystopianism, which treated its rise in speculative writing as an inevitable response to modern history. Robert Elliott, for example, asserted that '[t]o believe in utopia one must have faith of a kind that our history has made nearly inaccessible', while Mark Hillegas viewed the decline of such faith as 'one of the most revealing indexes to the anxieties of our age'.¹² Significantly, the term 'dystopia' itself can claim Cold War origins. This was revitalized by Glenn Negley and J. Max Patrick in 1952 to distinguish the condition of absolute degeneracy from that of imagined perfection, conceived by Thomas More as a unity of 'eu topos' (good place) and 'ou topos' (no place).¹³ As the latter phrase suggests, there was another, more pressing reason for rejecting More's coinage. Dystopianism not only 'represents the fear of what the future may hold if we do not act to avert catastrophe', in Ruth Levitas's words,

⁹ F. S. Northedge and Audrey Wells, *Britain and Soviet Communism: The Impact of a Revolution* (Basingstoke: Macmillan, 1982), p. 128.

¹⁰ Chris Ferns, *Narrating Utopia: Ideology, Gender, Form in Utopian Literature* (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 1999), p. 109.

¹¹ Fredric Jameson, *Archaeologies of the Future: The Desire Called Utopia and Other Science Fictions* (London and New York: Verso, 2005), p. xi.

¹² Robert Elliott, *The Shape of Utopia: Studies in a Literary Genre* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1970), p. 87; Mark R. Hillegas, *The Future as Nightmare: H. G. Wells and the Anti-Utopians* (Carbondale and Edwardsville: Southern Illinois University Press, 1974), p. 3.

¹³ *The Quest for Utopia: An Anthology of Imaginary Societies*, ed. by Glenn Negley and J. Max Patrick (New York: Schumann, 1952), p. 248.

but can also form what Erika Gottlieb calls 'an accurate reflection of the "worst of all possible worlds" experienced as a historical reality'.¹⁴ Gottlieb's reference is to post-1945 eastern Europe, where mass arrests, show trials, political terror, and the suppression of dissident writers indicated a world 'that complies in its essential features with [. . .] the hypothetical societies of the Western classics of dystopian fiction'.¹⁵ This connection elevated a previously minor genre into one of great cultural importance. Transcending the ideological stand-off between East and West, and the literary contest between Socialist realism and the avant-garde, dystopian fiction related such Soviet writers as Anatolij Ribakov, Andrei Sinyavski, and Vladimir Voinovich to the American postmodernists, who could be equally apprehensive of historical trends.

The themes of British Cold War dystopianism emerged fully formed in Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949), a novel that guided speculative fiction for the next forty years. In the famous tale, an atomic war has led to the emergence of three international coalitions, centred on Russia, China, and the United States, each of which has achieved internal stability but which still pursues, via conventional weaponry, an ongoing war with the others to control the labour and resources of peripheral territories in Africa, Asia, and the Middle East. In this global impasse Britain has been reduced to a satellite of the US, renamed as Airstrip One and governed by an oligarchy who, despite professing a form of Socialism, pursues power for the sake of power, sustaining it through propaganda, surveillance, and terror. 'One does not establish a dictatorship in order to safeguard a revolution', an inner party member tells Winston Smith: 'one makes the revolution in order to establish the dictatorship. The object of persecution is persecution [. . .]. The object of power is power.'¹⁶ Orwell was adamant that his target was any authoritarian regime, not merely Stalinist Russia, as suggested by the location of Britain within a US-dominated bloc and by the derivation of material from the author's wartime experiences at the BBC.¹⁷ Nevertheless, the novel was widely received as a right-wing polemic and was reprinted in American mass-circulation magazines and reproduced as a feature-length film to promote the cause of the 'free world'. The funding of the latter by the US government illustrates Frances Stonor Saunders and

¹⁴ Ruth Levitas, *The Concept of Utopia* (Hemel Hempstead: Allan, 1990), p. 165; Erika Gottlieb, *Dystopian Fiction East and West: Universe of Terror and Trial* (Montreal: McGill-Queen's University Press, 2001), p. 17.

¹⁵ Gottlieb, p. 17.

¹⁶ George Orwell, *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, new edn (1949; repr. Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1983), p. 227.

¹⁷ As he wrote, 'My recent novel is NOT intended as an attack on Socialism or the British Labour Party (of which I am a supporter)' (letter to Francis A. Henson, in *The Collected Essays, Journalism and Letters of George Orwell*, ed. by Sonia Orwell and Ian Angus, new edn, 4 vols (1968; London: Penguin, 1970), iv: *In Front of Your Nose 1945-1950*, p. 564).

David Caute's notion that the Cold War was a cultural as much as a military conflict, whose 'full arsenal' of weaponry included literature, cinema, music, and art, and whose foot soldiers were 'ballerinas, violinists, poets, actors, playwrights, painters, composers, comedians, and chess players'.¹⁸ In this context *Nineteen Eighty-Four* became an 'ideological superweapon', one that profoundly affected the British image of Soviet Russia, the object of so many Socialists' utopian aspirations.¹⁹ It also impacted on the generic conventions of speculative fiction. William Steinhoff's belief that '*Animal Farm* and 1984 mark the close of an era that has [retained] the vision of Utopia' may be overstated, neglecting such works as Robert Graves's *Seven Days in New Crete* (1949) and Aldous Huxley's *Island* (1962), as well as partly encouraged by Orwell himself, who has a character point out that Oceania is 'the exact opposite of the stupid hedonistic Utopias that the old reformers imagined'.²⁰ Yet as this essay aims to show, few subsequent speculations on the future departed from Orwell's fundamentally Cold War matrix of tripolar conflict, US dominance, nuclear anxiety, propaganda, tyranny, and oppression.

One of the most recurrent of these concerns was modern military technologies and their rapid proliferation in the thermonuclear age. Krishan Kumar, pondering the aspects of 'contemporary history that have rendered all utopian aspirations illusory', highlights the fact that '[t]o totalitarian tyranny and world domination was now added the spectre of nuclear annihilation'.²¹ Whereas in 1945 only the United States possessed an atomic arsenal, by 1984 around 50,000 nuclear warheads existed around the world, a growth rate of some four warheads per day and a combined capacity equivalent to 3-7 tonnes of TNT for each member of the world's population.²² Convinced that such force was necessary for an independent foreign policy, Britain tested its own bomb and delivery system in the early 1950s, developing the hydrogen bomb in 1957 and purchasing the American Polaris missile system in 1963. During the 1970s and 1980s it went on to acquire the Trident system and to allow US cruise missiles onto British soil, despite the fact that British

¹⁸ Frances Stonor Saunders, *Who Paid the Piper? The CIA and the Cultural Cold War* (London: Granta, 1999), p. 20; David Caute, *The Dancer Defects: The Struggle for Cultural Supremacy during the Cold War* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2003), p. 5. For covert funding of Michael Anderson's 1984 (1956), see Saunders, pp. 295-98, and Tony Shaw, *British Cinema and the Cold War: The State, Propaganda and Consensus* (London: Tauris, 2001), pp. 106-13.

¹⁹ Isaac Deutscher, '1984 - The Mysticism of Cruelty', in *George Orwell: A Collection of Critical Essays*, ed. by Raymond Williams (Englewood Cliffs, NJ: Prentice-Hall, 1974), pp. 119-32 (p. 119).

²⁰ William Steinhoff, *George Orwell and the Origins of '1984'* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1975), p. 216; Orwell, *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, p. 230.

²¹ Krishan Kumar, *Utopia and Anti-Utopia in Modern Times* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1987), pp. 380-81.

²² Mikhail A. Milshtein, 'On the Question of Non-Resort to the First Use of Nuclear Weapons', in *No-First-Use*, ed. by Frank Blackaby and others (London: Taylor and Francis for Stockholm International Peace Research Institute, 1984), pp. 111-20 (p. 112).

membership of the US-led NATO had proved deterrence enough from Soviet attack. Martin Amis, in an introduction to a collection of post-apocalyptic short stories, denounces the colossal overproduction of nuclear weapons, the inevitable failure of a deterrence that could never conceivably be deployed, and the likely scale of the threatened destruction. As he writes,

Prompt radiation, superstellar temperatures, electromagnetic pulse, thermal pulse, blast overpressure, fallout, disease, loss of immunity, cold, dark, contamination, inherited deformity, ozone depletion: with what hysterical ferocity, with what farcical disproportion, do nuclear weapons loathe human life [. . .]. It is possible to imagine nuclear synergisms multiplying into eternity, popping and crackling away, inimical to life even when there is nothing left to be inimical to.²³

The extent of this 'hemispherical butchery [. . .] is not thinkable, not by human beings, because the eventuality it posits is one in which all human contexts would have already vanished' (p. 8). This existence beyond language and consciousness ('Nuclear weapons repel all thought, perhaps because they can end all thought' (p. 18)) is for Amis the source of British novelists' imputed lack of coverage of the Cold War balance of terror. While accepting that a good percentage of science fiction 'is set beyond the holocaust', he laments the lack of engagement on the part of literary novelists, both those of an older generation, whose careers bestride what he calls 'the evolutionary firebreak of 1945', and those of a younger generation, who are only 'beginning to write about nuclear weapons' (pp. 18, 19). This is all the more lamentable, Amis argues, because 'Art celebrates life' and consequently 'raises the stakes, increasing the store of what might be lost' (p. 19).

Alongside Amis's short stories, however, a number of dystopian texts addressed the theme, including novels by William Golding, Russell Hoban, Emma Tennant, Aldous Huxley, L. P. Hartley, and, most notably, J. G. Ballard, who showed an unerring ability to realize imaginatively the unimaginable. Although Ballard's futures often originate in meteorological or geographical calamities, rather than in nuclear disaster *per se*, the pollution, carnage, and ruin described in *The Drowned World* (1962), *The Drought* (1965), and *The Day of Creation* (1987) are central features of nuclear anxiety. The point is clear in the early Reagan-era *Hello America* (1981), which charts the 'decline and fall' of the Western superpower.²⁴ Here, the oil crisis of the 1970s has spiralled out of control, leading to an economic collapse that reverses US history, the population turning initially to primitive agriculture and then abandoning the continent altogether, many travelling east to sail from New York to American colonies in Europe, where minimal industrial production is continuing.

²³ Martin Amis, 'Introduction: Thinkability', in *Einstein's Monsters*, new edn (1987; London: Penguin, 1988), pp. 1–23 (p. 17).

²⁴ J. G. Ballard, *Hello America*, new edn (1981; London: Vintage, 1994), p. 43.

By 2030, in effect, '[t]he government and nation of the United States ceased to exist' (p. 47). Thereafter, climatic engineering projects conducted by the new world government, designed to aid European food production, cause ecological disaster across north America, signalled by clouds of radioactivity drifting across the Atlantic from decaying nuclear arsenals and power stations. A team of scientists sail from Plymouth, ostensibly to investigate the leakage but privately driven by a need to escape 'a tired and candle-lit Europe with its interminable rationing and subsistence living, its total lack of any flair and opportunity' (p. 9). The team's resemblance to the original pioneers is confirmed as they trek westward—in 'the American direction' (p. 84)—through great deserts and abandoned cities, encountering nomadic tribes descended from the few thousand Americans who had remained. It is not long before they dream of becoming the forty-fifth president, or at least a 'colonial administrator [. . .] of thousands of miles of arid wilderness', and of restoring the nuclear infrastructure to bolster their rule (p. 28). Upon reaching Las Vegas, however, they find the dream already realized. Thanks to a working nuclear generator, a community of earlier visitors has been able to maintain food production, energy supplies, and communication systems, as well as a stockpile of nuclear warheads. Its leader, President Manson, is fearful of Russian invasion and not only regenerates Titan and cruise missiles, but also blows up nuclear plants to create a radioactive 'Maginot Line' (p. 145). In short, the nuclear threat continues even after disaster has taken place, resurrected by the ambitions of all continental settlers. Although the scientists view Manson as a 'mad war-lord', 'his happy finger on the launch buttons of his nuclear missiles', their desire 'to see America great again' would have produced the same wayward leadership (pp. 212, 190, 146).

The notion that nuclear-fuelled superpowerdom is the natural endpoint of a depraved human history was suggested in other dystopian novels. Collectively, the post-apocalyptic society as foreseen in Huxley's *Ape and Essence* (1949), Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954), Hartley's *Facial Justice* (1960), Hoban's *Riddley Walker* (1980), and Amis's *Einstein's Monsters* (1987) is sunk in savagery, superstition, infanticide, tribalism, genetic mutation, and devil worship, yet is still troubled by violent new elites craving absolute power.²⁵ For many Cold War writers, curiously, this critique of political ambition was complicated by regret for Britain's international prestige. Faced with a nation in political and economic decline, John Brannigan argues, novelists often 'survey[ed] the landscape of the post-imperial aporia [. . .] with a mournful, backward stare', obsessed by 'the themes of loss, disappearance, remembrance

²⁵ The tendency to foresee primitive power struggles emerging from social or political upheaval is also found in John Wyndham's *The Day of the Triffids* (1951), Anthony Burgess's *The Wanting Seed* (1962), Doris Lessing's *The Memoirs of a Survivor* (1974), and Emma Tennant's *The Crack* (1973) and *Queen of Stones* (1982).

and nostalgia'.²⁶ An inevitable corollary of this was an aversion to the country that had usurped Britain's role as global leader. In dystopian fiction, Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) was already satirizing American patterns of mass production, consumption, entertainment, and leisure, a trend continued in the Cold War by Evelyn Waugh's *The Loved One* (1948) and John Wyndham's *The Day of the Triffids* (1951). Ballard's *Hello America* makes similar digs at the nation's materialism, evoking a culture as unlikely to spread civilization as the former European empires, but also expresses lingering respect for its social dynamism. Despite one character referring to America as 'an emotive symbol [that] went out of fashion in the 1980s and 1990s', the author viewed the novel as 'strongly on the side of the U.S.A., and a celebration of its optimism and self-confidence'.²⁷ One wonders to what extent Ballard's fascination with US '[i]mperial splendour' derived from his childhood encounters, in Japanese prison camps, with imperial humiliation (p. 42). Certainly Fredric Jameson, who views Ballard as 'the greatest of modern apocalyptic writers', sources his fascination with death and social disintegration in 'his experience of the end of the British Empire in the Second World War', where he witnessed 'the canceled future of a vanished colonial and imperial destiny'.²⁸

For Britain, the growing power of the United States was also manifesting itself closer to home, as Orwell's 'Airstrip One' had anticipated. Over and above its calls for the decolonization of British territories considered strategically or economically important to Washington was the presence, from the late 1940s, of US atomic aircraft and military personnel at RAF bases in Britain itself, operating outside the domestic chain of command and making the country 'the bull's eye of a Soviet attack'.²⁹ In response, anti-nuclearism grew within the Labour Party and the peace movement, which after the creation of CND in 1958 helped to encourage Labour to adopt a short-lived unilateralist policy. The story is taken up, fancifully, in Constantine FitzGibbon's pro-American *When the Kissing Had to Stop* (1960), one of those rare works of speculative fiction that envisages, not the fully formed dystopian future, but the events that bring that future about. A weak Conservative government, subordinate to US interests, is shaken by the strength of public protest against American nuclear bases, a development that bolsters the Labour opposition and its 'Anti-Nuclear Bomb platform'.³⁰ Further assisted by a Soviet declaration of unilateral disarmament, the opposition sweeps to power, quickly destroying its nuclear arsenal and dismantling the US bases, trusting national defence

²⁶ John Brannigan, *Orwell to the Present: Literature in England, 1945-2000* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2003), p. 74.

²⁷ Ballard, *Hello America*, p. 162; and Ballard's introduction, pp. 4-5 (p. 5).

²⁸ Jameson, pp. 199, 288.

²⁹ Churchill, quoted in David Reynolds, *Britannia Overruled: British Policy and World Power in the Twentieth Century*, new edn (1991; Harlow: Pearson Education, 2000), pp. 170-71.

³⁰ Constantine FitzGibbon, *When the Kissing Had to Stop* (London: Cassell, 1960), p. 10.

to an alternative 'special relationship' with the post-Khrushchev Kremlin. Unknown to the Socialists, however, the Soviet announcement is merely a ploy designed to pave the way for invasion. Through a series of secret manoeuvres, Moscow replaces the Labour leadership with the quisling Rupert Page-Gorman, a rising star with a snappy line in anti-American rhetoric ('Must we die that the Pentagon generals may live?' (p. 11)). Having weakened political resistance, the Soviets then send over an inspectorate, tasked with confirming British disarmament, that in reality is the advance guard of an invasion force. 'The electorate was deceived', one character bemoans: 'They voted for disarmament. What they will get [. . .] is Russian domination' (p. 167). This link between nuclear capability and national freedom is made by a disaffected Air Chief Marshall, who reacts by planning a military *coup d'état* and, when that fails, by leading an ineffectual guerrilla unit hiding out in the Welsh mountains. For FitzGibbon, the proper solution is found in the actions of Patrick Clonard, a minor aristocrat and veteran of the Korean War. Stumbling upon the conspiracy in its early stages, Clonard tries to enlist the support of Washington, which, proving itself highly responsible, refuses to contravene international law by deposing an elected government, but has 'no intention of abandoning Europe', reaffirming the 'Atlantic alliance' through '[m]oral support, economic support, information, advice' (p. 182).³¹ After the Soviet occupation of Britain is complete, it is the US that pushes for an international response at the UN General Assembly:

The resolution, sponsored by Canada and Ecuador, deplored recent events in Britain, and called for respect for the fundamental human rights of the British people and for their distinctive cultural and social life [. . .]. The voting was 45 in favour of the motion, with 19 against and 26 abstentions. (It was commented upon, but regarded as purely incidental, that the wording of this resolution was almost identical to that sponsored by Ireland and Malaya at the time of the Tibetan genocide of 1959: only a single, and presumably embittered, French journalist noted that the United Kingdom, as it was then, had abstained from voting for or against the Tibetan resolution, on legalistic grounds.) (p. 245)

The fact that the British People's Republic, as it is now known, is spoken of in the same breath as the nation's former colonies—Canada, Ireland, Malaya—is as pertinent as its resemblance to Chinese-occupied Tibet. Indeed, once the Soviets have assassinated Gorman, installed a Russian general as dictator, and either interned or exiled much of the population via 'a grandiose act of social engineering' (p. 246), Britain's post-1945 ambition of spearheading continental security is cruelly mocked. As the Soviet leaders are aware, if Britain had remained 'the closest ally of the world's most powerful state, America', it

³¹ FitzGibbon, who was of Anglo-Irish and American parentage and who served in the US Army during the Second World War, thus manages to reconcile potentially divided national loyalties by imagining a reinvigorated British aristocracy in alliance with the US government.

would still be 'the greatest power in Europe' (pp. 219–20). The point is used to expose the naive anti-Americanism of the peace protesters: Britain's Atlantic ally, far from seeking to 'conquer and subdue us by the power of the mighty dollar' and by the 'atomic bases that ring our coasts', is the only defence against Soviet dominion.³² As Alan Sinfield comments, 'right-wing stories are even more urgent when they are less plausible', and *When the Kissing Had to Stop* gained considerable success as a novel and film, one *Daily Mail* reviewer asserting that it 'relegates Orwell's 1984 and Huxley's *Brave New World* to the nursery'.³³

The novel's portrait of rising tensions, defections, espionage, censorship, and purges certainly captured the anxieties of a British establishment caught between US and Soviet centres of power, particularly its views of the latter. The Soviet threat was a common motif in fiction, with novelists as diverse as Muriel Spark, Brigid Brophy, John Wain, Lawrence Durrell, John Le Carré, and Malcolm Bradbury pursuing, through disparaging representations of the Communist East, a form of imaginative containment. These were little different from the images circulated by Whitehall propagandists: in Menno Spiering's words, the Soviets were seen as 'shrewd plotters [. . .] with a considerable amount of psychological insight' and a partiality for 'supreme suppression and absolute control'.³⁴ In dystopian fiction, FitzGibbon's images of left-wing fanaticism and intrigues were echoed in Evelyn Waugh's 'Scott King's Modern Europe' (1946), a satire on Yugoslav Communism, D. M. Thomas's *The Flute-Player* (1979), a bleak portrait of Soviet censorship, and Kingsley Amis's *Russian Hide and Seek* (1980), a 'condition of England' novel set some fifty years into Soviet occupation. The more fantastical the political allegory, it seems, the more useful it was for Russophobic stereotypes. In John Wyndham's *The Midwich Cuckoos* (1957) a 'prosaic English village' is shocked to discover that all women of childbearing age are implanted with fertilized ova, giving birth to identical children of no 'known racial classification'.³⁵ As the children mature and begin to take 'efficient step[s] in dictatorship', the authorities realize that an alien power is conquering the nation not 'by launching a probably costly, and certainly destructive, assault', but by 'introduc[ing] a fifth column, to attack it from within' (pp. 167, 96, 96). The fact that implantations have also occurred in the Soviet Union, as well as in various 'free world' countries, does not offset the impression that these 'Ivans', as one character refers to them, are allegorical Russians (p. 28).

³² FitzGibbon, pp. 10–11. Macmillan once stated that peace protesters are 'sinister and hang about the Soviet Embassy more than I would wish' (quoted in Greenwood, p. 164).

³³ Alan Sinfield, *Literature, Politics and Culture in Postwar Britain* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1989), p. 98.

³⁴ Menno Spiering, *Englishness: Foreigners and Images of National Identity in Postwar Literature* (Amsterdam: Rodopi, 1992), p. 155.

³⁵ John Wyndham, *The Midwich Cuckoos*, new edn (1957; London: Penguin, 2000), pp. 150, 89.

The impression is confirmed by such clichéd traits as rigid group mentality, ruthless intelligence, emotional coldness, 'institutionalism in their dress', and indifference towards 'normal social and legal rules'.³⁶ This fear of internal revolution predominated in dystopian fiction, which often hypothesized the nature of a Communist Britain. L. P. Hartley's *Facial Justice* (1960) imagines an egalitarian state demanding even physiognomical uniformity from citizens; Waugh's 'Love among the Ruins' (1953) foresees surveillance, social engineering, and state-sanctioned euthanasia of 'welfare-weary citizens'; and Emma Tennant's *The Last of the Country House Murders* (1974) describes the bungled efforts of a post-revolution government to eliminate the remaining aristocracy (a novella that Waugh might well have enjoyed).³⁷

The scale of the supposed danger was most brutally captured in Anthony Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange* (1962). The novel concerns a working-class teenage gang, led by the fifteen-year-old Alex, which rebels against bourgeois authority via a campaign of physical assault, rape, and murder. The text's satire is directed not at a domestic political system—a highly regimented, though rarely mentioned, industrial capitalism—but at the identification with Soviet culture exhibited by British teenagers. These meet in a milk bar called 'Korova', frequent a record shop called 'Melodia', and listen to the songs of Johnny Zhivago and Ed and Id Molotov.³⁸ If Cold War Europe was, as Alistair Davies argues, 'the site—at the level both of high and popular culture—of the struggle for cultural legitimacy', then it was a struggle that Burgess felt the West was losing.³⁹ Most obviously, the gangs have developed a private language that combines Cockney and archaic idioms with a crude, demotic Russian ('off his gulliver'; 'your little droog'; 'bolshy big' for the pleonastic 'great big' (pp. 126, 61, 35)). Termed 'Nadsat' after the Russian for 'teen', the argot entails an infiltration into working-class vernacular of the linguistic forms of the ideological adversary and, according to one reading of the text, thus encourages in British teenagers the depravity that the author locates in that adversary. A violent assault on an old woman, for example, is largely facilitated by the dehumanizing vocabulary of Alex's narration: 'there was

³⁶ Ibid., pp. 125, 131. Wyndham's critique of the Soviet Union is also found in *The Day of the Triffids*, with the origin of the deadly plants lying in Soviet biological experimentation, and in *Web* (1979), where descriptions of an enlightened, though ultimately doomed, utopian settlement resemble 'a show of Russian posters depicting the future of the New Lands' (John Wyndham, *The Day of the Triffids*, new edn (1951; Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1954), pp. 31–37; *Web*, new edn (1979; London: Penguin, 1980), p. 11).

³⁷ Evelyn Waugh, *The Ordeal of Gilbert Pinfold; Tactical Exercise; Love among the Ruins*, new edn (1957; Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1962), p. 196.

³⁸ Anthony Burgess, *A Clockwork Orange*, new edn (1961; Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1972), pp. 24, 109, 36.

³⁹ Alistair Davies, 'Britain, Europe and Americanisation', in *British Culture of the Postwar: An Introduction to Literature and Society 1945–1999*, ed. by Alistair Davies and Alan Sinfield (London and New York: Routledge, 2000), pp. 103–09 (p. 104).

this vindictive starry forella with her wattles ashake and grunting [. . .], so I gave her a malenky fair kick in the litso, and she didn't like that, crying: "Waaaaah," and you could viddy her veiny mottled litso going purplewurple where I'd landed the old noga' (p. 51). Once the teenagers are conditioned by the Russian language—or satan'd, to use an anagrammatic form of Nadsat—they appear better able to sate their addiction to 'ultra-violence'. However, a second reading is offered by one of Alex's psychologists, who associates the Slavic roots of Nadsat with 'Propaganda. Subliminal penetration' (p. 91). This suggests that, behind Alex's understanding of gang violence as a counter to 'the government and the judges and the schools', as a crusade against the 'big bloated capitalist', lies an absorption, not of Soviet Communism, but of the Western propagandists' image of that Communism, revealing an internalization of 'free world' ideologies (pp. 34, 43). Either way, the author's anxieties are focused upon a teenage demographic which, after the 1950s, combined greater social presence with an openness to left-wing politics.⁴⁰

As Burgess's later work would illustrate, the Soviet Union was not the only perceived threat to British national security. From the 1960s, events in the Middle East threatened to derail détente, as the gradual withdrawal of Britain's imperial presence, hastened by US geopolitical expansion, led to fears about the spread of nationalism among the newly sovereign nations, particularly after their decision to wrest control of oil pricing from Western export companies.⁴¹ This was exacerbated by the start of the Arab-Israeli War in late 1973, when the Arab nations exerted political pressure on the West by quadrupling oil prices, casting Britain into a decade of inflation, recession, strikes, and unemployment. With these events in mind, Burgess's 1985 (1978) combines the anti-Communism typical of Cold War dystopias with 'an alternative picture [. . .] of the conditions to which the seventies seem to be moving'.⁴² In a Britain now christened 'Tucland', after the acronyms for 'The United Kingdom' and 'Trades Union Congress', forty-five years of chiefly Labour government have allowed the ascendancy of working-class culture. For Burgess, this means tabloid newspapers, unwholesome cuisine, 'gimcrack furniture', and inferior pastimes ('beer, football, pools, darts'), as well as a replacement of 'Bourgeois English' by a simplistic 'Worker's English' centred on 'limitations appropriate to a non-humanistic highly industrialised society' (pp. 169, 167, 168, 221). More worryingly, the nation is incapacitated

⁴⁰ This is despite the text's rejection of conditioning as a solution to Alex's delinquency and despite Burgess's sense that teenage violence is partly caused by a Cold War atmosphere of 'wars and bombs and nonsense' (*Clockwork Orange*, p. 35).

⁴¹ As Peter Odell writes on post-imperial Europe, 'for the first time in some 400 years, the western world had lost control over an essential element in its system to a set of countries which had hitherto not been considered as decision-taking entities of any international significance' (Peter Odell, *Oil and World Power*, new edn (1970; Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1983), p. 227).

⁴² Anthony Burgess, 1985, new edn (1978; London: Arrow, 1980), p. 19.

by syndicalism: semi-permanent strikes afflict all industries, the workforce is controlled via mandatory union membership, and even the government is cowed by a TUC that 'can hold a whole nation dithering in fear' (p. 168). In contrast to 'East European Socialism', with its 'repressive state systems which denied syndicalism', the TUC masters the nationalized economy by retaining the government as a symbolic 'employer' and waging an unceasing struggle against it on the part of the 'employees' (pp. 136, 120). Such collective tyranny leaves little scope for individual agency, as the novel's protagonist discovers. Bev Jones is a former schoolmaster who, enraged by his wife dying in a hospital fire during a firemen's strike, protests against the closed shop by championing 'liberty and decency' and 'an employee's right to work', a protest that leads to redundancy and physical punishment (p. 130). Yet Burgess's hero, the archetypal bourgeois individualist, has more to worry about than trade unions. With the loss of British imperial control 'East of Suez', the Middle East is starting to exert an influence over national life: not only is the economy dependent on investment and energy from a union of Islamic states ('[t]he oil [. . .] flowed in from Islam and kept 'Tucland's industries going'), but the culture is steadily Islamicized, as seen in the preponderance of mosques, muezzins, and 'buildings flying the flag of the star and the crescent' (pp. 120, 196). Paradoxically, Tucland's Marxist vision of a heaven on earth is incompatible with 'a people that believed in a heaven hereafter', with the latter represented as far 'more fanatical' (pp. 121, 183). Yet so essential is Arab investment that the TUC relaxes its laws on private ownership:

The Arabs were in Britain to stay. They owned the Al-Dorchester, Al-Klaridges, Al-Browns, various Al-Hiltons and Al-Idayinns, with soft drinks in the bars and no bacon for breakfast. They owned things that people did not even know they owned, including distilleries and breweries. And, in Great Smith Street, soon would stand the symbol of their strength—the Masjid-ul-Haram or Great Mosque of London. To remind Britain that Islam was not just a faith for the rich, plenty of hard-working Pakistanis and East African Muslims flowed in without hindrance, for the adjustment of the immigration laws [. . .] in favour of the Islamic peoples was a necessary political consequence of Arab financial patronage. (p. 121)

In such passages, Islamophobic tropes become the primary mode of 'cognitive estrangement', that process of defamiliarization central to dystopian fiction.⁴³ Yet although London is viewed as 'the commercial capital of Islam', and subsequently 'as Islamic territory', it is not subject to full occupation (p. 199). In order to gauge how effective this might be, Saudi Arabia finances a 'Pan-Islamic take-over' of Alderney and Sark, producing a '[m]uzzled press and radio', an '[e]nforcement of Islamic law', a 'conversion of Jesus Christ

⁴³ M. Keith Booker adapts the term from Darko Suvin's summary of the techniques of science fiction. See M. Keith Booker, *The Dystopian Impulse in Modern Literature: Fiction as Social Criticism* (London: Greenwood, 1994), p. 19.

into Nabi Isa', and a violent suppression of native dissent (pp. 205–06). Further radicalized, Bev joins a shadowy organization called the 'Army of Free Britons', which appears to be a patriotic resistance movement but turns out to be a private army funded by Arab sheikhs and led by an English proto-Fascist who prefers an Islamic oligarchy to syndicalist godlessness. With Bev's wife already lost to union negligence and his only daughter abducted by a sheikh, all that remains is a 'choice of tyrannies' (p. 235). Indeed, so impotent is the cause of liberty in post-imperial Britain that the impasse is broken, not by domestic events, but by a shift in the Middle Eastern balance of power. As rumour has it, the Islamic union is broken by an Iranian declaration of war on the Arab nations, and, with the US backing the Iranian Shah, all Arab investment is withdrawn from American banks, threatening the collapse of Western economies and Western syndicalism. In 1985, Britain is no longer a 'pigmy' between the US and Soviet 'giants', yet still finds itself a victim, rather than an agent, of Cold War history.⁴⁴

Burgess's comprehensive failure to predict even the immediate future (the Iranian Revolution of 1979, the eight-year Iran–Iraq War, the US sponsoring of Saddam Hussein) pales in comparison to his class prejudice and racist paranoia. The novel offers evidence for Jean Pfaelzer's argument, ostensibly about nineteenth-century American speculative fiction, that dystopianism 'is formally and historically, structurally and contextually, a conservative genre'.⁴⁵ Nevertheless, the British dystopian novel was occasionally a medium for dissent, not least against the kind of geopolitical dichotomies that Burgess supported. As Noam Chomsky points out, there were clear 'theological overtones' to US constructions of East–West division, a feature that Anders Stephanson, reflecting on its 'language of evil plots, sins and sinners, demons and saviors, corruption and redemption', traces back to seventeenth-century 'radical Protestantism'.⁴⁶ The manipulation of language became so central to psychological warfare, in British as well as American rhetoric, that many commentators view it as the defining feature of the age. 'A Cold War is a rhetorical war', Martin Medhurst argues: 'a war fought with words, speeches, pamphlets, public information (or disinformation), campaigns, slogans, gestures [and]

⁴⁴ The political dichotomies found in dystopian fiction often have Cold War resonances: see the disputes between ecology and business in Emma Tennant's *The Crack* (1973), between rationality and irrationality in Alan Sillitoe's *Travels in Nihilon* (1971), and between Enspun and Ruspun (an English-speaking and Russian-speaking empire) in Anthony Burgess's *The Wanting Seed* (1962).

⁴⁵ Jean Pfaelzer, 'Parody and Satire in American Dystopian Fiction of the Nineteenth Century', *Science-Fiction Studies*, 7 (1980), 61–72 (p. 61).

⁴⁶ Noam Chomsky, *Towards a New Cold War: Essays on the Current Crisis and How We Got There* (London: Sinclair Browne, 1982), p. 74; Anders Stephanson, 'Liberty or Death: The Cold War as US Ideology', in *Reviewing the Cold War: Approaches, Interpretations, Theory*, ed. by Odd Arne Westad (London: Cass, 2000), pp. 81–101 (p. 84).

symbolic actions'.⁴⁷ As a consequence, many dystopian texts reflected on the impossibility of distinguishing between fact and fiction in the public sphere, including texts by right-wing novelists. For example, Burgess's *Nadsat* and Orwell's *Newspeak*, both of which recall the early Cold War pessimism of Hartley's *Facial Justice*, where language is reduced to a 'storehouse of dead metaphors', promoting 'a common consciousness which reacted to stimuli in precisely the same way', a degeneration also captured in Julian Barnes's 'TAT tongue' and Tennant's 'New Accent'.⁴⁸

Perhaps the most sophisticated treatment came in Angela Carter's *The Infernal Desire Machines of Doctor Hoffman* (1972). As narrated by Desiderio, a young civil servant, the story is set around an unnamed South American city that boasts traditions of human reason, 'perfect propriety', and 'smug [. . .], bourgeois affluence'.⁴⁹ The peace is shattered when the eponymous doctor, a diabolical magician, lays siege to the city with a bombardment of images and apparitions, such as 'chanting pillars', 'winged jaguars', 'imaginary massacres', and 'women in states of pearly, heroic nudity' (pp. 18, 19, 20, 19). The city's Minister, to repulse 'the ferocious artillery of unreason', attempts an alternative manipulation of reality through 'propaganda broadcast[s]' to the besieged townsfolk and through absolutist decrees on signification: that is, 'a strict control of [. . .] actualities by adjusting their names to agree with them perfectly', thus ensuring that 'no shadow would fall between the word and the thing described' (pp. 12, 206, 194, 194). After introducing these 'ideological weapons', the Doctor's battery of mirages merely 'bounced off the intellectual walls the Minister had built' (p. 194). These Cold War tropes—of containment and non-military conflict over the control of truth—are augmented by the emerging similarity of the two antagonists. For Desiderio, who becomes a secret agent tasked with hunting down and assassinating the Doctor, an experience of both warring factions soon destabilizes their positions in the binary schemata. Alongside the tool of propaganda, the Minister places law and order in the hands of the 'Determination Police', whose 'primitive and increasingly brutal methods' and regulation 'belted coats of black leather' could

⁴⁷ Martin Medhurst, introduction to *Cold War Rhetoric: Strategy, Metaphor, and Ideology*, ed. by Martin Medhurst and others (New York: Greenwood, 1990), pp. xiii–xv (p. xiv).

⁴⁸ L. P. Hartley, *Facial Justice* (London: Hamilton, 1960), pp. 116, 59; Julian Barnes, *Staring at the Sun*, new edn (1986; London: Pan, 1987), p. 147; Emma Tennant, *The Last of the Country House Murders* (1974; London: Faber, 1986), p. 40. For Burgess, Orwell, and Amis, linguistic restriction already existed in official discourse: see the links between Orwell's sense of 'sheer cloudy vagueness', Burgess's notion of 'pure verbalisation', and Amis's description of 'nuclear management' speak (Burgess, 1985, p. 235; Orwell, 'Politics and the English Language', in *Collected Essays*, new edn (London: Secker and Warburg, 1961), pp. 353–67 (p. 363); Amis, 'Thinkability', pp. 4–5).

⁴⁹ Angela Carter, *The Infernal Desire Machines of Doctor Hoffman* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1982), pp. 12, 16.

have 'been recruited wholesale from a Jewish nightmare' (pp. 23, 22). If the Doctor's methods are 'totalitarian', as Desiderio believes, then the Minister's are equally so, particularly as the latter has 'all the Faustian desires', including dreams of 'megalithic grandeur' and an 'envy for the [Doctor's] power to subvert the world' (pp. 207, 28, 29, 28). Once again, a Cold War hero is required to choose between tyrannies:

I might not want the Minister's world but I did not want the Doctor's world either. All at once I was pitched on the horns of a dilemma, for I was presented with two alternatives and it seemed to me that the Doctor must be wrong for neither alternative could possibly co-exist with the other [. . .]. And I was in the unhappy position—I, of all men, had been given the casting vote between a barren and harmonious calm and a fertile yet cacophonous tempest. (p. 207)

What further complicates the choice is a suggestion that the Doctor's 'cacophonous' images—indeed, the Doctor and his minions themselves—are projections of the city's unconscious. For all the citizens' attempts to police their borders, 'to keep what was outside, out, and what was inside, in', Desiderio senses that 'the enemy was inside the barricades, and lived in the minds of each of us', the apparitions being 'emanations of [our] own desires' (pp. 12, 12, 186). Most obviously, he is convinced that mirrors form 'fissures or crannies in the hitherto hard-edged world of here and now and through these fissures came slithering sideways all manner of amorphous spooks' (p. 12). In Philip Taylor's words, this is the East-West conflict as 'looking-glass war', one in which two superpowers, 'star[ing] aggressively at each other through the Iron Curtain, [. . .] were in fact seeing a reflection of themselves'.⁵⁰ On this level, Carter seems to refute the construction of geopolitical others by analysing what the waging of Cold War does to the self, finding paranoia, despotism, and self-division. Yet her deconstruction of Western ideological assumptions occasionally repeats them. Interspersed within the symbolic structures of her allegorical conflict are the very real markers of Cold War history: despite the Doctor's resemblance to the Fascist of 'Jewish nightmare', he hails from a 'mountainous Slavonic principality', has followers whose clothing imitates 'the style worn by Lenin and the Bolsheviks', and espouses, in the contradictory rhetoric of Marxism-Leninism, the '[a]bsolute authority to establish a regime of total liberation' (pp. 26, 47, 38). The fact that the tale is set in South America, one of the period's most vital arenas of hot war, compounds the allusion. The political system that is finally re-established, which 'throve on business' and caused extensive 'squalor [that] the city fathers in their veranda'd suburbs contrived to ignore' (pp. 15, 16),

⁵⁰ Philip Taylor, 'Through a Glass Darkly? The Psychological Climate and Psychological Warfare of the Cold War', in *Cold-War Propaganda in the 1950s*, ed. by Gary D. Rawnsley (Basingstoke: Macmillan, 1999), pp. 225-42 (p. 226).

reflects the right-wing regimes installed by US interventionism between 1954 and 1990, further associating the Doctor with the left-wing movements that opposed those regimes.

Carter's *The Infernal Desire Machines* was part of a new wave of British dystopian fiction which, during the drift to the 'second Cold War', addressed contemporary history with a distinctly postmodernist sensibility. Alongside its scepticism towards metanarratives, those totalizing systems of belief which confine and channel human knowledge, the speculative writing of Carter, Ballard, Barnes, Tennant, Ian McEwan, and Salman Rushdie displays all the stylistic flourishes of historiographic metafiction. Indeed, the techniques used to evoke their futures—language games, convoluted plots, paranoid conspiracies, deferrals of closure—bear a mimetic relation to the political and experiential intricacies of Cold War history, not least to the ontological notion of superpower conflict as a constructed or staged reality. As Chris Megson argues, an attachment on the part of world leaders to both rhetorical drama and the rhetoric of drama—'actors', 'theatres of operations', 'iron curtains'—exposes 'the performative underpinnings of superpower politics'.⁵¹ For Mary Kaldor, similarly, this was an 'imaginary war', one that existed only 'in the scenarios of military planners, in the games and stories of espionage and counter-espionage [. . .], in the hostile rhetoric of politicians and newspapers', and one that also, with a 'fortuitous complementarity', 'specified the character of blocs' and worked 'to maintain social cohesion'.⁵² The suspicion that a vast project of social engineering underlay political rhetoric emerges most clearly in the authors' treatment of technology. The 'reality modifying machines' of Doctor Hoffman are matched elsewhere by two-way 'telescreens', 'novel-writing machines', 'Verse-Transcribers', 'electronic spies', 'truth-evacuating drugs', 'psychic Y-ray photographs', 'soft-termination facilities', and 'all the latest gadgets of capital and corporal punishment', each aiming to curtail psychological autonomy and the creative imagination.⁵³ Barnes's *Staring at the Sun* (1986), for example, foresees a computer program that stores 'the whole of human knowledge' and then places users under surveillance, modifying or blocking its responses and making knowledge 'subject to political manipulation'.⁵⁴ If there was a single cause of the Cold War 'para-

⁵¹ Chris Megson, "Is it chaos? Or is it a building site?" *British Theatrical Responses to the Cold War and its Aftermath*, in *Cold War Literature: Writing the Global Conflict*, ed. by Andrew Hammond (London and New York: Routledge, 2006), pp. 46–62 (p. 46).

⁵² Mary Kaldor, *The Imaginary War: Understanding the East-West Conflict* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1990), pp. 4–5.

⁵³ Carter, *Infernal Desire Machines*, p. 211; Orwell, *Nineteen Eighty-Four*, pp. 8, 115; Ballard, *Vermilion Sands* (1971), new edn (1973; London and Melbourne: Dent, 1985), pp. 153–54; Adrian Mitchell, *The Bodyguard* (London: Cape, 1970), p. 166; Hartley, *Facial Justice*, pp. 29, 48; Barnes, *Staring at the Sun*, p. 142; Waugh, 'Love among the Ruins', p. 188.

⁵⁴ Barnes, *Staring at the Sun*, pp. 144, 146.

lysis of utopian thought and imagination', in Northrop Frye's phrase, then this was it.⁵⁵

The emotional and psychological impact of a politically motivated technology is explored in McEwan's *The Child in Time* (1987), a dystopian meditation on the likely consequences of a third term of the Thatcher government. Here, Stephen Lewis is a celebrated children's novelist whose success has brought involvement in government commissions and friendship with the nation's elite, including the Conservative politician Charles Darke. The tragic loss of his only daughter, however, leads to a separation from his wife and a loss of creative energy, a plight worsened by a 'sudden threat of global extinction'.⁵⁶ During the Olympic Games an altercation between an American and a Soviet athlete descends into fights between team-mates, coaches, and spectators, then to tensions between the respective ambassadors and presidents, who bring their nations' 'nuclear forces to their most advanced state of readiness': 'Nuclear submarines slid quietly to their allotted firing points, silos gaped open, missiles bristled in the hot shrubbery of rural Oxfordshire and in the birch forests of the Carpathians' (p. 35). Listening to a colleague recount how 'he and his wife had lain awake all night, speechless with fear', Stephen also becomes 'suddenly, childish, afraid' and reflects on how '[t]he world outside the room, outside his clothes even, seemed bitter, harsh beyond reason' (p. 163). The passage is typical of '[n]uclear anxiety texts', in Daniel Cordle's phrase, which dramatize 'the way in which personal and domestic relations and spaces become heavily politicised by external forces'.⁵⁷ The collapse of any demarcation between public and private space is seen when Charles announces his retirement from public office and Stephen receives a covert visit from a concerned Prime Minister. Before her entrance, a team of security men, engineers, and secretaries push past him, hauling equipment, taking photographs, and scanning the apartment with 'gazes fixed on details—the skylight in the hall, the box that housed the electricity meter, dado rails, skirting boards, doors' (p. 184). They then prepare for Thatcher's arrival:

The small dining room off his kitchen was being transformed into an office. One red, one black and two white telephones had been connected to the switchboard on which

⁵⁵ Northrop Frye, 'Varieties of Literary Utopias', in *Utopias and Utopian Thought*, ed. by Frank E. Manuel (London: Souvenir, 1973), pp. 25–49 (p. 29).

⁵⁶ Ian McEwan, *The Child in Time*, new edn (1987; London: Vintage, 1997), p. 34.

⁵⁷ Daniel Cordle, 'Beyond the Apocalypse of Closure: Nuclear Anxiety in Postmodern Literature of the United States', in *Cold War Literature*, ed. by Hammond, pp. 63–77 (p. 68). The symptoms of nuclear anxiety are common in dystopian texts: characters in Carter's novel feel 'a deep-seated anxiety and [...] profound melancholy', one of Tennant's young characters writes in a journal that 'the nukle war is started it is cumin', and both Ballard and Amis have a character that 'dreams of cruise missiles' or 'dreams of nuclear supercatastrophe' (Carter, *Infernal Desire Machines*, p. 20; Emma Tennant, *Queen of Stones*, new edn (1982; London: Picador, 1983), p. 119; Ballard, *Hello America*, p. 187; Amis, 'Insight at Flame Lake', in Amis, *Einstein's Monsters*, pp. 49–67 (p. 54)).

pinprick lights pulsed. The man with glasses was speaking on the red phone, reciting a long code [. . .]. It was beginning to look homely. A secretary was arranging on the table in- and out-trays, a thick pile of stationery, and a shallow box which contained coloured paper clips, drawing pins, rubber bands and a pencil sharpener in the shape of a tomato. Someone was bringing in an extra chair and asked Stephen to mind out the way. (p. 185)

The 'homeliness' of the scene belies the fact that the premier's nuclear hotline, and thus the wider technology of global nuclearism, has literally invaded Stephen's home. Importantly, the machinery of state power is utilized, not for the furthering of some grand belief system, but for the limited wish 'to keep order, and to defend the State against its enemies' (p. 28). This absence of governing ideology is a feature of all postmodernist dystopias, as is McEwan's inability to conceive a coherent oppositional philosophy. Most obviously, Adrian Mitchell's *The Bodyguard* (1970) and Michael Young's *The Rise of the Meritocracy* (1958), which satirize right-wing regimes of the future, also ridicule youth movements, revolutionary organizations, and the Labour Party, which has 'scrapped the appeal to working-class solidarity' and changed its name to the 'New Labour Party' (in Mitchell) or the 'Technicians Party' (in Young), becoming 'about as threatening to the State as convolvulus'.⁵⁸ Moreover, the above scene, which places in confrontation a writer and the political establishment, is also typical in evoking the powerlessness of literature in the face of authoritarianism. Stephen realizes that the meeting is 'an opportunity to give voice to an interior monologue which had been running for years, to confront the very person responsible', yet fails to articulate what he realizes are 'faded debating points' (p. 190). The pessimism of McEwan's generation is captured in exactly this self-reflexive foregrounding of artist figures—Carter's Hoffman, Burgess's Alex, Mitchell's Len Rossman, all literary descendants of Orwell's Winston Smith—that are more likely to support than to challenge the omnipotent state. A late example is the protagonist of Fay Weldon's *Darcy's Utopia* (1990), who, attempting to re-engage with life after her husband's imprisonment, outlines a beguiling vision of an idealistic egalitarian society in a series of newspaper and magazine interviews, using that utopianism, not for political change, but for personal financial gain.

In conclusion, the social forces, historical events, and competing ideologies of the Cold War had a profound effect on dystopian fiction. While acknowledging that late twentieth-century manifestations of the genre were in part shaped by 'the tradition established by Zamiatin, Huxley and Orwell', one should not underestimate the influence on its styles, concerns, and narrative structures of international history between 1945 and 1989, a history that for

⁵⁸ Michael Young, *The Rise of the Meritocracy 1870–2033*, new edn (1958; Harmondsworth: Penguin 1961), pp. 140, 141; Mitchell, *The Bodyguard*, p. 34.

Frank and Fritzie Manuel marks 'the twilight of utopia'.⁵⁹ Indeed, the events of the period form an essential interpretative framework for all post-1945 literature, from late modernism and postmodernism to such popular genres as adventure, horror, detective fiction, science fiction, and spy thrillers. A full account of Cold War literary practice demands not only new readings of British authors but also a comparative scholarship that attends, in Piette's words, 'to the interrelations between Anglo-American texts and the key dissident books of the Cold War [. . .], as well as the creative work from the decolonizing cultures of the Third World'.⁶⁰ The value of such criticism has not depreciated after 1989. The concurrence of the fall of the 'evil empire' and the rise of the 'axis of evil' reveals the importance of the earlier construct as a shaping influence upon a contemporary ideological conflict similarly fuelled by propaganda, power blocs, 'proxy wars', state terror, and surveillance technologies. 'The Cold War is not over', Suzanne Clark reminds us: 'it lives on in the imaginary where it was so firmly installed through nuclear trauma and phobia'.⁶¹ The analysis of how the Cold War impressed itself upon cultural production offers ways of forecasting the long-term cultural effects of the 'war on terror', while also providing an important guide to how cultural production can absorb and endorse the discourses of international conflict.

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⁵⁹ Gottlieb, p. 112; Frank Manuel and Fritzie Manuel, *Utopian Thought in the Western World* (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 1979), p. 757.

⁶⁰ Piette, p. 212.

⁶¹ Suzanne Clark, *Cold Warriors: Manliness on Trial in the Rhetoric of the West* (Carbondale: Southern Illinois University Press, 2000), p. 14.